



Week 1 - Summary



What the Algorithm Actually Does

- **Job:** Filter & rank millions of videos to find the *best few dozen* for each user.
- **Two-part process:**
 - **Picking** the right videos → Based on watch history, behavior, personalization.
 - **Ranking** them → Based on performance signals (CTR, AVD, Satisfaction).



Key Ranking Signals

- **CTR** (Click-Through Rate): Driven by *title, thumbnail, idea*.
 - *Lemonade Stand Analogy*: High CTR in a small pond ≠ more growth than lower CTR in a big pond.
- **AVD** (Average View Duration): Influenced by *length, pacing, editing, storytelling*.
- **Satisfaction**: Harder to track, but crucial.
 - Positive: Likes, shares, multiple video views (Comments= minimal impact)
 - Negative: Dislikes, unsubscribes, early exits.



Understanding Traffic Sources

- **Browse**: Homepage + subscription feed (~3% of views).
- **Suggested**: **Powerful**, cluster-based (related videos).
- **Search**: Relevance matters; tags don't.
- **External**: Not trackable by YouTube ("dead views").



Reframing: It's Not About the Algorithm: It's About the Audience

- Instead of "How do I beat the algorithm?" → Ask "How do I better serve my audience?"
- **YouTube serves viewers, not creators.**

3 Steps to Understand Your Audience

1. **What cluster are we in?**
 - Look at suggested traffic, other channels tab, YouTubeAtlas.com.
2. **How big is our audience (TAM)?**
 - Use competitor data, niche estimates.
 - Ask: *Could casuals enjoy this too?*
3. **What is our audience truly like?**
 - Ask: What do they value, find funny/helpful, or ignore?
 - Build an *audience avatar* to guide content (see template in Recordings)

Audience Insight Tools

- Pattern recognition (Top 10% vs bottom 10% of videos).
- Post-mortem box drill for flops: Why did we think it would work vs why it didn't?
- Retention curves, comment sentiment, personal intuition.

Shorts Algorithm

- **Why post Shorts:** No downside, fast growth, long-form bridge.
- **How it works:** Personalization + VVSA (Viewed vs Swiped Away) + AVD.
 - <65% VVSA = unlikely to perform.
 - Longer Shorts often outperform.
 - Links to long-form videos can prime higher retention.

Why a Video Might Suddenly Drop

- CTR decline: Title/thumbnail fatigue, audience saturation.
- AVD drop: Fringe viewers don't stick.
- Satisfaction dip: Didn't meet expectations.
- Other causes: Viewer exhaustion, algorithm shifts, other videos outrank it.